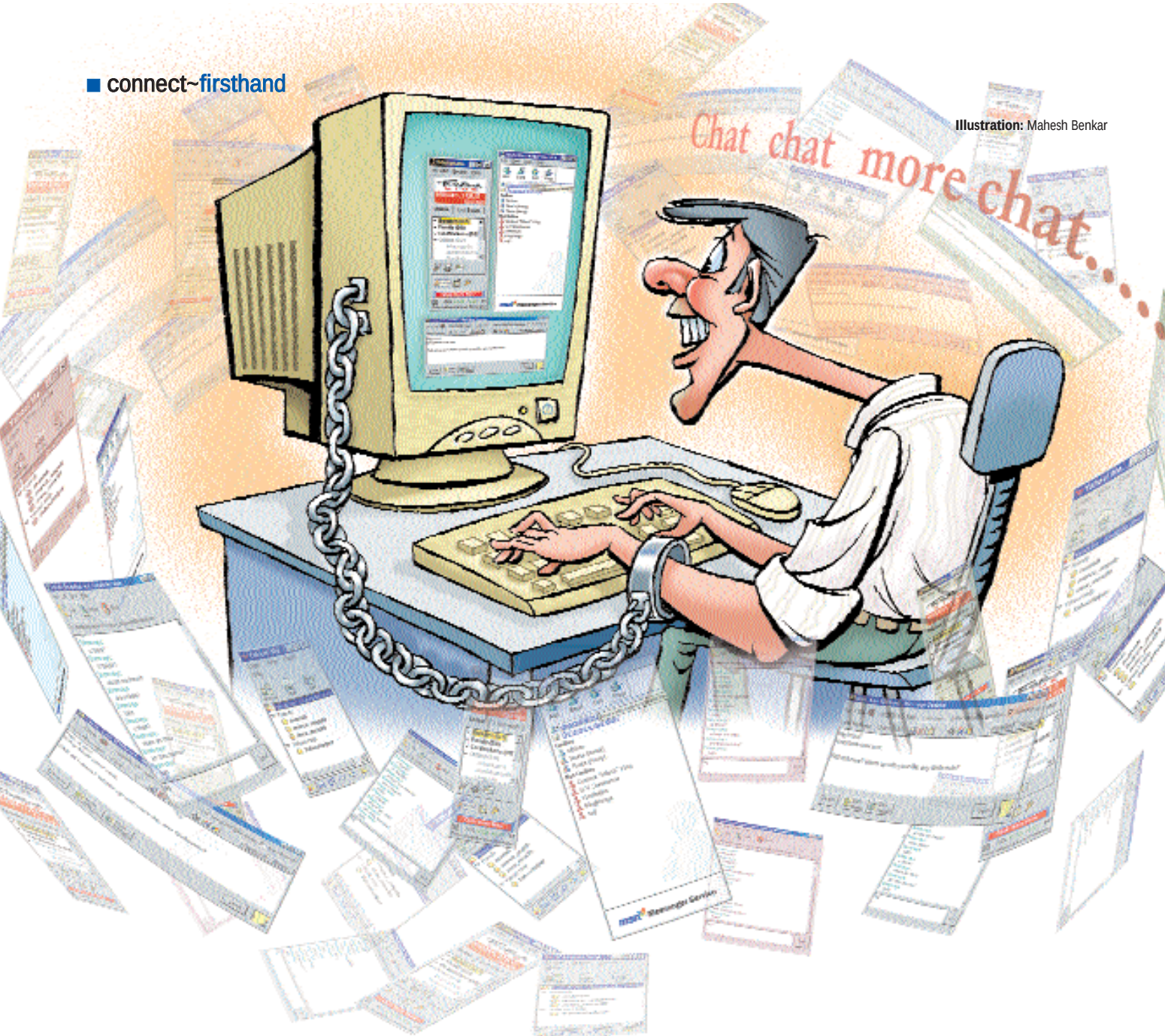




Trapped in the Web

Instant Messengers: a boon or a bane?

SRIRAM SHARMA

It's 1.00 in the night, and you meet the same bunch of anonymous names at IRC. Behind the pixelated glare of the screen, the distinction between inner and outer worlds almost disappears. You sit almost motionless, your hands typing away to cryptic names who are as immersed in this world as you are.

Topgun: Hey look guys we got a newbie in our midst!

Necromancer: How often do you come here bookitty?

Bookitty: I m new here don t borg me o sages of lotekville.

Topgun: Hey, poots! You still here? Get a life!

Poots: I don t have one, tops!

Necromancer: Hiya Smokey! You back again? I saw you this morning.

Sir Smokalot: I needed another fix... LOL!

(Writer's note: sic sic sic!)

Studies conducted of late seem to confirm various anecdotal accounts of people being 'hooked' to the life online, at the cost of their